even down to the medieval Qing period (1644–1911). In the writings of Chinese Buddhist monks and scholars during the Han, Sui and Tang dynasties (roughly from the first century BCE to the tenth century CE), it was India that was often described as the centre of the world, not China. This reverence for India was in sharp contrast to the later claim to centrality that marked Chinese narratives. We should note that in Chinese descriptions, India was not one single, unified entity but a civilized, even spiritual space, occupied by several kingdoms and ruled by several kings. There was a clear awareness of the country's diversity but also an understanding of its overarching oneness derived from both culture and religious faith.

Though China became aware of India in these early years of the first millennium, physical contact among the people was rare and an exception rather than the rule. Few Indians or Chinese actually had face-to-face encounters with each other. Knowledge about India and Indians was mostly mediated through the intermediate zone of Central Asia, Tibet and South-East Asia, which geographically separated the two countries. For example, India and its culture, the tenets of Buddhism and descriptions of its geography were conveyed through peoples inhabiting the Central Asian oasis towns like Balkh, Khotan and Kucha. These people included the Sogdians, the Parthians, and later the Arabs. There were communities of Indian traders resident in Chinese cities, and there may have been Chinese traders residing in Indian ports and towns. During the Tang dynasty (618–906 CE), there was an Indian quarter in Changan, the cosmopolitan capital of the Tang.

Nevertheless, these direct contacts were isolated, infrequent and superficial in nature. This continued to be the case up until the nineteenth and twentieth centuries, when familiarity with each other arose among the Chinese and Indians as a consequence of British imperialist forays into China and East Asia. The context of these more direct and wider contacts was not always a pleasant one from the Chinese perspective. Chinese contemporary awareness of India became a subset of its traumatic encounter with the West. The India in the millennial imagination of China as an independent centre of civilization, spirituality and knowledge, but